Township of NIPISSING
"Life the way it should be" ESTABLISHED 1888

The Corporation of the Township of Nipissing
45 Beatty Street
Nipissing ON P0H 1W0
Telephone 705-724-2144 Fax 705-724-5385
www.nipissingtownship.com

REPORT TO COUNCIL

Date: January 13, 2026

From: Kristin Linklater – Deputy Clerk, Administrative Assistant.

Re: Website

The purpose of this report is to inform Council of the current condition of the Township's website, outline recent technical issues and associated risks, and explain why a website upgrade has become increasingly urgent after being deferred for several years due to competing priorities.

The Township's website is a critical communication tool used daily by residents, businesses, government ministries, visitors, staff, and Council. It provides essential information including bylaws, notices, meeting agendas and minutes, service updates, emergency communications, and community resources.

For several years, staff have identified the need to modernize and redesign the website. However, this initiative has repeatedly been deferred due to other operational priorities. As a result, the website is now operating on outdated infrastructure and is increasingly vulnerable to failures, compatibility issues, and service disruptions.

In addition to being outdated, the current website does not fully meet modern accessibility standards. This creates barriers for residents who rely on assistive technologies and increases the Township's risk of non-compliance with the Accessibility for Ontarians with Disabilities Act (AODA) and best practices.

The Township's website currently uses the Agama theme for its layout and design. This theme was last updated in 2021 and has since been discontinued by its developer. As a result:

- The theme no longer receives security patches, bug fixes, or compatibility updates.
- It may not function reliably with newer server software or WordPress updates.
- Technical issues are more difficult to diagnose and resolve due to lack of ongoing support.

The website is effectively running on outdated technology and is becoming increasingly fragile as external systems continue to evolve.

In recent weeks, the Township experienced a visible error message appearing on the website following a server-side PHP security update applied by the hosting provider (Vianet). While the immediate issue was resolved, this incident highlights broader concerns.

Based on discussions with Stephanie van Doleweerd (AloeRoot Web Service) our web consultant:

The hosting provider updated the version of PHP running on their server. Because the website's theme is outdated, it was not fully compatible with the newer PHP version. While the error message was removed, it is unclear whether the underlying compatibility issue was fully resolved or simply hidden from public view.

This incident is considered an early warning sign. While the most recent issue was fixable, future updates or security patches may result in more serious problems that are not easily resolved, potentially leading to website downtime or loss of functionality.

It is important to note that the Township receives excellent support from our web consultant, Stephanie, who has been proactive, responsive, and thorough in identifying issues, communicating risks, and assisting staff with troubleshooting and recommendations.

While the Township does not currently have a formal website support or maintenance agreement, there are ongoing operational costs associated with hosting, email services, backups, training, and issue resolution.

Summary of Website-Related Costs (2023–2025):

- **2023 Total:** $1,090.22
- **2024 Total:** $1,034.18
- **2025 Total:** $1,155.18
- **Web Hosting fees** include staff and Council email accounts and email storage.
- **AloeRoot costs (Stephanie)** are primarily related to website backups, staff training, and issue resolution, not discretionary enhancements.
- **2024 costs** included a licensing fee.
- **2025 costs increased** due to more frequent backups and additional troubleshooting required as the platform becomes less stable and increasingly difficult to maintain.

These figures demonstrate that while the Township has minimized formal support expenses, costs are trending upward as staff and consultants are required to reactively manage issues caused by an aging and unsupported platform. Continued deferral of modernization is likely to result in higher reactive costs over time.

This lack of access and formal support increases risk and reduces the Township's ability to respond promptly if a critical issue arises.

Additionally, a WordPress update is expected in the near future, which may further increase compatibility risks given the age and discontinued status of the current theme.

The Township is now operating the website on what can reasonably be described as borrowed time. Key risks include:

- Increased likelihood of recurring errors following server or security updates

- Potential website outages or partial loss of functionality
- Reduced ability to post emergency or time-sensitive information
- Security vulnerabilities due to outdated software
- Reputational risk if residents are unable to access accurate and timely information

Each future update applied by the hosting provider or WordPress itself increases the chance of a critical failure.

Staff recommend that Council formally acknowledge the growing risks associated with maintaining the current website and consider prioritizing:

1. Planning for a full website redesign and modernization, using a supported and regularly updated platform.

Proactively addressing these matters will reduce long-term risk, improve reliability, and ensure the Township's website continues to meet the needs and expectations of the community.

Please find attached a quote on web page update/renew using our current consultant, AloeRoot.

The 2026 Budget has not yet been approved. Staff recommend Council approve this expenditure in order to proceed with the update.



Kristin Linklater

Attached:

2025	Web Hosting	AloeRoot	Total
January	$70.82	$74.74	$145.56
February	$68.69	$0	$68.69
March	$113.46	$0	$113.46
April	$68.69	$0	$68.69
May	$68.69	$156.10	$224.79
June	$72.13	$0	$72.13
July	$75.56	$0	$75.56
August	$75.56	$0	$75.56
September	$77.69	$0	$77.69
October	$76.83	$0	$76.83
November	$76.83	$0	$76.83
December	$79.38	$0	$79.38
Total	$924.34	$230.84	**$1,155.18**

2024	Web Hosting	AloeRoot	Total
January	$63.60	$0	$63.60
February	$63.60	$99.22	$162.82
March	$104.30	$0	$104.30
April	$63.60	$19.84	$83.44
May	$66.73	$57.24	$123.97
June	$66.14	$0	$66.14
July	$66.14	$0	$66.14
August	$66.14	$0	$66.14
September	$66.14	$0	$66.14
October	$66.14	$33.07	$91.21
November	$66.14	$0	$66.14
December	$66.14	$0	$66.14
Total	$824.81	$209.37	**$1,034.18**

2023	Web Hosting	AloeRoot	Total
January	$57.24	$0	$57.24
February	$57.24	$0	$57.24
March	$97.94	$0	$97.94
April	$57.24	$0	$57.24
May	$57.24	$19.84	$77.08
June	$59.07	$0	$59.07
July	$59.07	$0	$59.07
August	$58.51	$66.80	$125.31
September	$58.51	$0	$58.51
October	$177.57	$0	$177.57
November	$64.75	$0	$64.75
December	$63.60	$135.60	$199.20
Total	$867.98	$222.24	**$1,090.22**

2025 – There were increased fees due to more frequent back up, fixing things because the platform is failing.

2024 – There was a licensing fee associated with the costs.

The majority of Stephanie's fees are website back ups and training.
Web Hosting fee's include Staff/Council Emails, Email Storage.

AloeRoot Web Services

265 Sixth Ave West, North Bay, ON, P1B 3P4
steph@aloeroot.com | 705-493-3601

Web Site Proposal for:

Township of Nipissing

January 14, 2026

Project Goals:

From our discussions, we have identified the following objectives for your project:

- Rebuild website to modernize design and update content, replace theme
- New accessibility-ready theme similar to other municipalities
- Audit old pages and remove unneeded ones – township staff to do this
- Accessibility tools added
- Accessibility training for staff
- Design and features similar to Memphis, TN city website; see design brief
- Features from Memphis site: Events Calendar, Mega Menu, potential Embed Press Pro add-on required, potential license for accessible professional theme.
- Pop-up notice or alert on homepage for important events such as fire or road closures

Initial Budget (Plus HST if Applicable):

Basic Setup Cost for Wordpress:

$4999 CAD for setup, design and configuration of one Wordpress site. This charge includes site-wide design, search engine optimization, configuration of a responsive theme designed to scale for handheld devices. This also includes support for removing and redirecting outdated pages, and reworking of existing content to be accessibility compliant.

Design Options and Pricing:

These themes are listed as "accessibility-ready", meaning they are designed to meet most mandated accessibility standards. We still highly recommend you augment the accessibility of your theme with add-on accessibility software.

AloeRoot's Preferred Theme Choice:

https://wordpress.org/themes/neve/ based on Accessibe's evaluation of it being most compliant and also customizable to be similar to your design brief. See: https://accessibe.com/blog/knowledgebase/ada-compliant-wordpress-themes

Business License: $149 USD for the first year, $299 USD/year for renewals. Includes priority tech support for theme-related issues.

Additional Choices Based on Design Fit:

https://wordpress.org/themes/kadence/
https://wordpress.org/themes/oceanwp/

Accessibility Add-Ons:

AloeRoot's first choice would be UserWay software, as per below. We are aware that some accessibility companies can't support municipalities, so the Township's and AloeRoot's preference might be overruled by any license restrictions we discover in the process.

"UserWay" Accessibility Software Add-On: $490 USD/year for as long as the site has fewer than 100K page-views per month. Includes remediations for AODA and other legal requirements, monitoring of 10 important pages, a customized accessibility statement, and a litigation support program.

OR (Second Choice)

"Accessibe" Accessibility Software Add-On: $490 USD/year for as long as the site has fewer than 5K visits per month. Includes remediations for AODA and other legal requirements, an accessibility widget, a customized accessibility statement.

2. Conversion of all remaining pages to new "Gutenberg" block editor in Wordpress. AloeRoot and the Township staff can work together on this process to future-proof the content and consider accessibility.

3. Installation of new theme and switch to new theme for the design phase: approximately three weeks once content has been converted.

4. Concurrent process of refining the design, adjusting the content to fit the new design, creating new content as needed, and auditing and testing the site for accessibility compliance. Timing will be based on both AloeRoot and Township staff's availability.

5. Approval and launch process. This involves us coordinating with Vianet, the web host, to replace the existing site with the new version.

Maintenance and Updates:

Please note that we request a 50% deposit. The remainder will be billed incrementally depending on the duration of the project.

Software Maintenance and Updates After Launch:
Wordpress generally releases 4 core software updates per year, and occasionally you will require additional maintenance on your site's plugins and design theme. We charge our standard shop rate of $80/hour and bill in 15-minute increments for maintenance. We require that your website be kept updated, to prevent potential security problems from unpatched software. Annual maintenance costs tend to be in the range of $100/year for software updates.

Ongoing Accessibility Compliance:

AloeRoot will provide an accessibility-ready theme, train your staff, and help ensure that the site's content is considered accessible. Add-on software will provide additional tools and help protect the township from legal complaints. We do recommend asking us to do semi-regular compliance checks on the site's content, as third parties sometimes provide items (posters, graphics, brochures) which might introduce issues into the site.

Please also be aware that any PDFs uploaded to the site may not be accessible unless they're created that way; this is not an issue we can resolve. Infographics aren't accessible by nature, but we can train your staff to improve this.

Additional Software:

Wordpress itself is free of charge, however some add-ons require a commercial license. Based on your design brief using the Memphis website as an example, we expect you'll need:

The Events Calendar Pro: $149 USD/year to create an events calendar with recurring events, location search, advanced widgets, events manager

Mega Menu: $29 USD/year, creates accessible, multi-level flyout menus

Embed Press Pro: $69 USD/year, needed only if the Township wants to embed content from social media like Facebook or Instagram, or to display PDFs with advanced controls.

Optional Stock Photos: available at cost; we have an account with iStockphoto.com to provide images as needed.

Approximate Initial Costs:

- $4999 CAD for Wordpress work by AloeRoot
- $149 USD for Neve Theme business license
- $490 USD for UserWay accessibility add-on
- $149 USD Events Calendar Pro licence
- $29 USD Mega Menu license
- $69 USD for Embed Press Pro (optional)

Expressed in CAD: $6179 plus applicable tax as of current exchange rates.

Timeline:

We intend to handle the redesign of the Nipissing site by creating a working copy of the existing site, which Township staff can then edit to remove outdated content and update outdated information. Because the process depends on both Nipissing staff capacity and ours, accurately predicting our needs is challenging. However, we know the site's existing theme is reaching the end of its useful life, so there is some urgency.

Suggested stages:

1. Clone the site and township staff audit content: this can begin immediately, and the staff will delete unnecessary pages first. Train the staff in accessibility and how to create and maintain compliance, so the edited and new content is already compliant.

Training:

Training generally requires approximately 45-90 minutes when conducted with 1-5 staff members. One training session is included in the cost of your site. AloeRoot provides a handbook which includes guides to all the major functions of the site, which greatly reduces your need to pay for technical support following the launch of the site. However, support and additional training is available during business hours.

We offer consulting, support, and update services at our shop rate of $80/hour.

Thank you for your interest in working with us. Please call or email if you have any questions.